ALBANIA · RIVIERA & ALBANIAN ALPS

Albania

10 Day Riviera & Accursed Mountains Road Trip

DESTINATION
Albania, Riviera & Albanian Alps

DURATION
10 days

IDEAL FOR
2–5 people

YOUR JOURNEY

Expedition Route

Albania · Riviera & Albanian Alps · 10 days

DAY 1
Tirana · Skanderbeg Square · New Bazar

DAY 2
Tirana · Llogara Pass · Riviera

DAY 3
Himare · Jala · Ionian Coast

DAY 4
Himare · Qeparo · Borsh · Porto Palermo

DAY 5
Porto Palermo · Ksamil · Butrint

DAY 6
Saranda · Gjirokaster

DAY 7
Gjirokaster · Berat

DAY 8
Berat · Shkoder

DAY 9
Shkoder · Komani Lake · Fierze

DAY 10
Valbona · Theth (mountain traverse)

JOURNEY HIGHLIGHTS

- Llogara Pass — the mountain road that delivers you to the Riviera in a single descent
- Butrint — a 2,500-year-old archaeological site in a lagoon on the Greek border
- Komani Lake — a fjord-like mountain reservoir crossed by a two-hour ferry
- Ksamil Islands — four turquoise islets in water the colour of the Maldives
- Gjirokastër — the UNESCO Ottoman hilltop city of stone houses and a hilltop castle
- Valbonë to Theth — the classic Albanian Alps traverse, one of Europe's finest day hikes

DAY 1

Tirana — Skanderbeg Square & the New Bazar

Arrive at Tirana International Airport. The capital has changed faster than any city in Europe since 2000: the concrete has been painted, the Blloku district opened, the Lana River uncovered. Begin at Skanderbeg Square — the national monument and equestrian statue at the city's centre — then walk north through the New Bazar to the Et'hem Bey Mosque. Afternoon at the National History Museum and the coloured buildings of the former communist quarter.

- Skanderbeg Square — the vast city-centre square with the equestrian statue of Albania's national hero
- Et'hem Bey Mosque — the 18th-century mosque with painted interior frescoes, rare in the Islamic world
- New Bazar — the revived covered market with local produce, coffee and raki
- Blloku — the former communist elite quarter, now Tirana's café and nightlife district

INSIDER TIP

The New Bazar is most alive in the morning — arrive before 10am for the best produce and coffee. Blloku comes alive in the evening; locals eat dinner at 9pm or later. Raki, the Albanian grape spirit, is offered everywhere — it is genuinely good and genuinely strong.

DAY 2

Llogara Pass — The Descent to the Riviera

Drive south from Tirana toward Vlorë, then up into the Llogara National Park. The pass road climbs to 1,025 metres through pine forest, then cuts sharply south with the first view of the Ionian coast: the full arc of the Albanian Riviera, four shades of blue, stretching to Greece. The descent is 18 hairpin bends and takes thirty minutes. Check in at Himarë. Sunset from the Venetian castle above the village.

- Llogara Pass — the mountain threshold between the Adriatic and Ionian coasts
- Llogara National Park — black pines, eagles and the last bears in the Albanian coastal range
- First Riviera viewpoint — the panorama that justifies the drive south
- Himarë Venetian Castle — the medieval fortress above the old Greek minority village

INSIDER TIP

The pass road can be closed after heavy rain — check conditions before driving. The descent from the pass is one of the great drives in the Mediterranean but requires full concentration; stop at designated lay-bys rather than photographing while driving. Himarë has limited accommodation — book ahead.

DAY 3

Himarë & Jala — The Ionian Riviera in Full

The Riviera day. Drive the coast road south of Himarë through the succession of bays and beaches: Livadh, Llamani, Jala. The water here is exceptionally clear — the Albanian coast has no heavy industry and very little agricultural runoff. Jala is the most photogenic: a narrow bay between limestone cliffs, accessible by a short road down from the main coastal highway. Afternoon at Palasa or Drymades Beach. Return to Himarë for dinner.

- Jala Beach — a narrow turquoise bay between limestone cliffs with no permanent development
- Livadh Beach — the longest beach on the northern Riviera, black and grey pebbles
- Drymades Beach — one of the few sandy beaches on the Riviera, with clear shallow water
- Coast road — the Albanian Riviera coastal highway rivals the Amalfi and Corniche

INSIDER TIP

The Riviera coast road has no barriers and steep drops — drive slowly and stop at designated viewpoints. Jala Beach access road is rough and requires clearance; the last 400 metres is best walked. Water shoes are useful on the pebble beaches.

DAY 4

Qeparo, Borsh & Porto Palermo

Drive south along the Riviera. Stop first at Qeparo: the village splits into an upper Ottoman settlement on the limestone hillside and a lower beach section, with the remains of a Byzantine castle above. Continue to Borsh — the longest beach on the Albanian Riviera at seven kilometres, almost entirely undeveloped. The castle of Borsh sits on the cliff above it, reached by a 20-minute walk. Afternoon at Porto Palermo: Ali Pasha's fortress on a small peninsula, three-sided by the Ionian.

- Qeparo old village — an Ottoman hilltop settlement with Byzantine fortifications above
- Borsh Beach — seven kilometres of unspoilt pebble beach below a medieval castle
- Borsh Castle — the hilltop fortress with views over the full arc of the southern Riviera
- Porto Palermo — the triangular fortress built by Ali Pasha of Ioannina on a sea peninsula

INSIDER TIP

Porto Palermo fortress is free to enter but has irregular opening hours — check the gate before making the detour. The Borsh Castle walk is unmarked; ask a local in the village for the path. Riviera heat peaks between noon and 3pm — plan swimming stops around this window.

DAY 5

Ksamil Islands & Butrint

Drive to Ksamil: the village at the southernmost tip of the Albanian Riviera, with four small islands accessible by a short swim or kayak from the beach. The water is the colour and clarity you usually associate with the Maldives or the Seychelles. Afternoon at Butrint: 2,500 years of layered civilisation — Greek theatre, Roman baths, Byzantine baptistery, Venetian tower — all inside a nature reserve on the edge of a lagoon. Return to Sarandë for the night.

- Ksamil Islands — four turquoise islets in a sheltered bay, the most Instagrammed spot in Albania
- Ksamil beach — the clearest water on the Albanian coast, calm and shallow
- Butrint — a UNESCO World Heritage Site with 2,500 years of continuous occupation
- Butrint lagoon — the wetland ecosystem surrounding the archaeological site

INSIDER TIP

Ksamil Islands are accessed by pedal boat or a 5-minute swim — the water is shallow and safe. Butrint gets crowded from 11am; arrive at opening time (9am) and work backwards through the site. The paths are uneven archaeological ground — wear proper footwear, not sandals.

DAY 6

Gjirokastër — The Ottoman Stone City

Drive north from Sarandë through the Drino Valley to Gjirokastër — the UNESCO city of stone. The old town is built on a steep hillside with a medieval castle at the summit and layered Ottoman tower houses below. Gjirokastër is the birthplace of both Enver Hoxha and Ismail Kadare: dictator and novelist, the two extremes of Albanian twentieth-century life. The Bazaar Quarter and the Old Bazaar are among the best-preserved Ottoman streetscapes in the Balkans. Overnight in the old town.

- Gjirokastër Castle — the medieval hilltop fortress housing a military museum and a captured U.S. spy plane
- Zekate House — a three-storey 18th-century Ottoman tower house open to the public
- Old Bazaar — the cobblestone market street below the castle with artisan workshops
- Ethnographic Museum — Enver Hoxha's birthplace, now a museum of Albanian domestic life

INSIDER TIP

Gjirokastër's old town is built on steep limestone cobblestones — walking shoes with grip are essential. The castle's captured American U-2 spy plane is the unexpected highlight of the military museum. The best hotels in the old town book up quickly in summer; reserve two weeks ahead.

DAY 7

Berat — The City of a Thousand Windows

Drive north through the Skrapar highlands to Berat: the other UNESCO Albanian city, built on a steep hill above the Osum River with Ottoman houses stacked so close together that their many windows face each other across the gorge. The Kalaja fortress sits at the top, still inhabited. Walk up through the Mangalem quarter and into the castle walls. Afternoon free to explore the lower city. Drive on to Shkodër in the north.

- Berat old town — the UNESCO Ottoman quarter of white-washed houses with identical bay windows
- Berat Kalaja — the inhabited Byzantine castle with churches converted to mosques
- Mangalem Quarter — the Muslim neighbourhood below the castle, one of Albania's finest streetscapes
- Osum River gorge — the canyon below Berat visible from the castle walls

INSIDER TIP

Berat Kalaja is a living neighbourhood — the people inside are residents, not actors. Walking up from Mangalem to the castle gate takes 20 minutes on steep cobbles. The Osum River gorge is visible from the castle walls; it is worth the 200-metre detour to the viewpoint.

DAY 8

Shkodër — the Gateway to the Alps

Arrive in Shkodër, Albania's northern city on the edge of Lake Shkodër — the Balkans' largest lake, shared with Montenegro. The Rozafa Castle occupies a promontory above the lake, with views back toward Tirana and north toward the Albanian Alps that are visible on clear mornings. The pedestrianised Kolë Idromeno Street is the city's social centre. Shkodër was once the capital of the Illyrian kingdom and has been fought over consistently ever since. It is now quiet, civilised and genuinely welcoming.

- Rozafa Castle — the Illyrian-era hilltop fortress above Lake Shkodër and the Buna River
- Lake Shkodër — the Balkans' largest lake, visible from the castle across its full expanse
- Kolë Idromeno Street — the pedestrian boulevard with the best coffee in northern Albania
- Historical Museum — the story of Shkodër from Illyrian times through Ottoman rule and communism

INSIDER TIP

Rozafa Castle is best in the late afternoon when the light catches the lake surface. Coffee culture in Shkodër is taken very seriously — Kolë Idromeno Street has the best espresso in northern Albania. Lake Shkodër is shared with Montenegro; boat trips are available from the Montenegrin side at Virpazar.

DAY 9

Komani Lake — The Ferry Through the Fjords

Drive east from Shkodër to the Komani Dam. The Komani Lake ferry is a two-and-a-half-hour boat journey through a reservoir that resembles a Norwegian fjord: sheer limestone walls 500 metres high, narrow passages between rock faces, occasional village landings where no road reaches. It is one of the strangest and most beautiful transport experiences in Europe. The ferry arrives at Fierzë. Drive the rough road to Valbonë in the late afternoon.

- Komani Lake — a man-made reservoir in the Drin canyon with fjord-like limestone walls
- Komani ferry — the passenger and cargo boat that serves villages with no road access
- Canyon passages — the narrowest sections where the boat moves through slot canyons
- Valbonë Valley National Park — the alpine valley at the end of the ferry route

INSIDER TIP

The ferry departs Koman Dam at 9am sharp — the drive from Shkodër takes 90 minutes on rough mountain road, so leave by 7am. Tickets are bought at the dock; no booking system exists. Bring food and water: nothing is sold on board. The upper deck and bow have the best views.

DAY 10

Valbonë to Theth — The Accursed Mountains Traverse

The classic Albanian Alps hike: 16 kilometres from Valbonë over the 1,793-metre Valbona Pass to Theth, through the highest and most dramatic mountain scenery in the Western Balkans. The ascent takes three hours through beech forest and alpine meadow; the descent into the Theth Valley reveals one of the most spectacular mountain views in Europe. Theth village: a handful of stone guesthouses, the lock-in tower, and the mountain church. The world feels very far away.

- Valbona Pass — the 1,793-metre crossing between the two most dramatic Albanian alpine valleys
- Theth Valley — a glacially carved valley surrounded by peaks above 2,500 metres
- Theth Church — the 19th-century stone church on the valley floor, still in use
- Kulla e Ngujimit — the lock-in tower where blood feuds were arbitrated under the Kanun

INSIDER TIP

Start the Valbonë–Theth hike no later than 7am to cross the pass before afternoon cloud builds. The trail is marked with red-and-white paint but the upper section can be obscured by snow until June. Pack 2 litres of water — there is one spring on the ascent. Walking poles help significantly on the descent.

HIDDENATLAS

Ready to make this trip yours?

This guide gives you the structure and route.
Our planners can build the personalised version around your dates, travel style and pace.

- Refined route planning and pacing
- Carefully selected areas to stay
- Logistics guidance for a smooth journey
- Insider tips from on-the-ground research

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